

Photograph by MANDAR DEODHAR

POOJA DHINGRA, 40
Founder & CEO, Le15 Patisserie
Mumbai

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Starting Le15 Patisserie at the age of 23, Dhingra, also a pastry chef and food influencer with over 6.6 million followers on Instagram, is credited with introducing French macarons to India, making them her retail chain's signature product

Pooja Dhingra's love for baking started early. She had little choice really, born as she was into a "food-obsessed family" in Mumbai where "almost everyone cooks and is an excellent cook". Just six when an aunt taught her how to make brownies, baking followed her through her teenage years, when she'd whip up confections for friends and family, and make goodies to take to school. "Food has been an integral part of my life, and I wouldn't know what else to do if it wasn't the food business," she says.

Food, though, wasn't what she set out to study first. It was law. But her stay in law school lasted precisely two weeks, before she realised she wasn't cut out for the profession. Food it would be, to pursue which she first moved to Switzerland to study hospitality and business management, and then to Le Cordon Bleu in Paris to study French patisserie. By year 2010, and age 23, she was back in Mumbai, ready to launch her venture: Le15.

Whipping dough was a passion, but making dough the harder part. At first, her age and gender worked against her: "Getting people to take me seriously was a problem. Everyone wanted to know where my father or husband was." The later challenges were ones any entrepreneur is familiar with: growth pangs, scaling the business, choosing the right team etc. But, as she says, "I've always been curious and keep learning. Whatever challenges come my way, I learn from them and move on."

HER ADVICE

"It is a tough business, but seeing someone enjoy what you make is also extremely rewarding. Don't give up when it gets tough, the tables always turn"

While in Paris, Pooja had tried the macaron, a sweet, meringue-based French sandwich cookie, which she later brought to India, the first pastry chef to do so. That was 16 years ago, and macarons remain Le15's biggest speciality. Recently, she opened a French-style cafe called Pardon Our French in Fort, Mumbai, creating a stir with its unique beverage programme and desserts. Going forward, she plans to focus on the distribution of products from Le15 Patisserie in Mumbai and scale other things digitally—her books, courses and her YouTube channel. The author of seven books, her first, *The Big Book of Treats*, came second at the Gourmand World Cookbook Award. Other titles include *The Wholesome Kitchen*, the bestselling *Can't Believe It's Eggless*, *Coming Home*, the Le15 Café Cookbook, *Bake At Home*. The latest, *Little Book of Cookies*, is written for children. Pooja, who has 6.6 million followers on Instagram, and 34,000 subscribers for her YouTube channel, also hosts a popular podcast, #NoSugarCoat, where she speaks to chefs, friends, mentors and other entrepreneurs about "the blood, sweat, tears and all the other ingredients that go into being an entrepreneur". ■

— M.G. Arun